the meeting with Ferreira by commenting that it was a pity it had taken four workplace fatalities in 11 months in Vale's Canadian operations to prompt the Vale CEO to engage directly with the union.[1]

In Canada, the union historically has played a major role in the day-to-day management of workplace relationships. The 200-page collective agreements include language to cover virtually every area of possible contention, with a mutually recognised set of steps for grievance procedures according to the seriousness of the infraction. Vale's desire, however, to marginalise the role of the union has included upping the ante in the grievance process, slapping step four grievances on what formerly were seen as minor infractions worthy of a step one, thereby creating huge backloads of cases needing formal arbitration procedures for their resolution. Anecdotally, workers mock the foolishness of the new management style which goes on the offensive even in the face of obvious company faults. A worker who tripped and had a minor arm injury in a darkened stairwell, unlit because management had not changed the light bulb, is given a formal reprimand for 'lack of awareness of his surroundings'!

Another characteristic of the big mining companies today is their preference for projects in remote areas, often 'fly-in, fly-out' enclaves. This serves as a way of keeping the intrusive nature of the mining project and their negative community and environmental impacts out of view of the general public. It is also a way of keeping workers separate from union organisers. Vale is using the enclave nature of its 'fly in, fly out' Voisey's Bay operation in Canada as a way to isolate its largely inexperienced workforce from participating in broader union events, like the international mining conference and the opportunity it provided to debate global trends. The National Office of USW is told frequently that Vale is using strict adherence to the rotations of the shifts, flying crews in and out every two weeks, as reason for not allowing its employees the leave for union activities stipulated in their collective agreements.

The delegates to the conference concluded that throughout the world big mining companies are showing a general tendency to push for health and safety as purely a management task with no recognition of workers' rights to participate. Vickers spoke of having left behind in Australia a huge dispute with BHP Billiton about the company's introduction of new policies to house all safety matters with supervisors. Ged Kearney, President of ACTU, a sister union in Australia, took up this question at a United Mineworkers Federation Memorial Day.

> Contractors are increasingly favoured by some mining companies over permanent employees because they are cheaper and many contractors